

you're certain will be discreet. You need to be very careful here. You want to be the first to announce your retirement, not the last. But with careful "what if?" questions, you can broach the subject with a close business associate or mentor.

Most important of all, talk to your spouse. I use the word *spouse* for convenience; *partner* or *companion* may be better words. More than anyone, he or she can help change your view of the world. And, more than anyone, he or she needs to accept your new life—and probably start to think about retiring with you.

Vicki worked the first several years after we married. But she always supported and nurtured me in my career. She moved us across the country while I was away on business trips. She changed her plans when I called unexpectedly to tell her a visiting client or partner was coming for dinner. She put up with my childish outbursts when I was under stress. She helped me think through the toughest decisions I had to make. Throughout the work years she enjoyed my promotions and raises. My success was her success.

So, when I said I wanted to retire, I pulled the rug out from under her. I was proposing to toss away what we had achieved together. She felt cheated and angry. Her response was to take another look at her life. If I was going to be so fickle, she was going to have to worry a bit more about number one. She decided to pay more attention to what she wanted and less to what I wanted.

We had profound, heart-to-heart talks on every aspect of retirement. We reviewed our relationship, roles, and chores. At times we seemed about as compatible as Greeks and Turks. We needed most of two years to prepare for the changes we saw coming.

It was a trying time in our marriage. She wanted to stay close to home. I wanted to travel. She was set on continuing most of her old activities. I wanted her to retire and spend more time with me. She wanted to put her needs first. I wanted her to keep giving me the attention I was used to.